Chapter 1

The Beginning of a Beautiful Journey

Lia

1st August 2002, 8:09 pm.

'Shit- Shit! SHIT!'

How am I supposed to tell him? Do I just hand it to him? Do I take him out to dinner first?

God! This is undoubtedly the *one* thing I can't be poetic about. I just can't start with "The moon kisses the Sun in anticipation for a longer eclipse" or some other bullshit!

'Your eyes are as big as my stomach will...'

Oh my god, it's happening; I'm moody. This is why people shouldn't fall in love. This is exactly why you don't have chocolate before meeting someone! Okay, maybe I'm going a little too hard on the snickers. It did nothing but set the mood. Maybe it is his fault! Maybe I need to get straight to the point! Maybe he doesn't need to know. I'm really losing my mind here.

Yup, there it goes, out the window, just like my career, ambitions, and will to live.

I honestly have no clue how to do this, but maybe you will. Maybe that is when you will know what's happening, and that's when this introduction will make sense, unlike the dramatic chaos it looks like now. First impressions matter; this wasn't how I intended mine to be. I was going to be someone great, or so I thought.

It's like I can still feel him on my skin while I lay bare on his silk bed. The white room is now a soft shade of orange as the sun almost says goodbye. His soft touch sent shivers down my spine. I swear I melt every time he kisses me

down my neck, his warm breath making me arch my back, his hands clasping against mine while my fingertips lace with his. As my lips linger on him, our tongues instantly greet each other, yearning for every inch of one another, just like our bodies. They want more of each other. Even though there's hardly any room, we still want to be closer.

At this moment, we were one. Our breathing synchronizes, and our eyes lock; the fire of his hazel eyes engulfs my vibrant blue orbs. Our movements get faster, and voices get louder, but our gaze remains fixed on each other. At some point, it becomes too much to maintain eye contact as pleasure takes over my body. My eyes roll shut, my head falls back, and my moans get louder with each thrust. I can tell he can't take it anymore either; his head leans into the crook of my neck as he groans and cusses under my breath. We couldn't get enough; we were at our peaks, but we still wanted it to last longer, so we slowed down again. Long, deep, and slow. Nose to nose, we knew we wanted more. We didn't want this to end. We always wanted to be this close.

"I fucking love you," he moaned against my neck, his breathing intense, his body further pressing against mine.

I returned the notion, lifting my fragile body to press against his as much as I could as I whispered into his ear, "I fucking adore you."

He wraps his arms around me and pulls me on top, his strong, muscular arms almost instantly tightening around my waist. Our eyes lock briefly until my lips crash into his once again. The pace gets faster, I move my hips in a circular motion that makes him pull away to moan against my mouth, but I hold onto his bottom lip. I feel him shudder and harden. He begins to rhythmically copy my motions while holding onto my hips. We want more, and, no matter how badly we want to keep going, this time, we know we can't hold back any longer. Our sweaty bodies are in sync, ready to burst any second. I'm throbbing at this point. His body tenses up. The room echoes with our continuous moans and screams that only get louder as we climax together. I tremble over him while he does the same under me, falling on his back. Yet, he still thrusts a few more strokes. Our hearts beat out of our chests as we try to catch our breath. The sensation doesn't leave my body, even after we finish

By the end of it, our bodies are covered in marks. His back is scratched and bleeding, and my neck and breasts go red and blue. These marks indirectly scream, 'I am his, and he is mine.'

The best part about it all? We're at it again within 20 minutes. All it takes is a soft, loving kiss. The truth is, we just can't get enough of each other. This is us expressing our unconditional love, wanting one another to *feel* every ounce of what we had caged in our chests.

This is exactly what happens when fire and water collide. One wants to burst into flames and burn everything, whereas the other wants to make it rain and send floods to the city.

Fuck, if I were given the chance to undo all of this—to save myself from the storm that began to make its way towards me—I'd still do it.

'Huh, anyways, let's skip to nine months ago. That's how you'll know how I ended up here and, Of course, what happens after.

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Lia

17th December 2001.

The Beginning.

With my college acceptance letter in hand and my chestnut hair in a messy bun, I stood before my grandparents, ready to break the news to them, but they could tell instantly from my light smile and bright blue eyes that glistened with excitement.

"You got in, didn't you?" my grandfather asked as he reached out for his wife's hand and squeezed it.

He, too, had a wide smile and a few tears in his eyes. The three of us embraced each other in an affectionate hug. Tears streamed down our faces as we tried to seize the moment. I can assure you they were excited, and I was too. But, we just couldn't ignore the fact that the acceptance letter in my hand meant that I was leaving for Seattle University within a week and a half. It also meant I'd be leaving behind everything I had ever known for the last eighteen years. This small part of Indiana was all I had ever known. This town, these people; these are *my* people. Don't get me wrong, it was always my dream to move to the city and explore, but now that it was here, I was scared. Leaving Grandpa and grandma just seemed like a crime, if I'm honest. They were my family, if not

by love, then by choice. They took me in, supported me, and loved me unconditionally while my own blood abandoned me.

My parents wanted a son and had been trying for years before I came into this world. And well, when my mother finally conceived, she was confident that it was a boy, so she didn't bother to get an ultrasound. Her 'instincts' proved her wrong, and the utter shock on her face expressed clearly that I was not what she wanted. Of course. I can only imagine this since I wasn't technically aware (I mean, I was just a baby, you know).

I found it hard to believe that a mother could be so upset that she'd refuse to hold a child just because of its gender. But, that's what the retired nurse told me about a year ago. I thought to myself last year that maybe I should know why they left. So I went to the hospital I was born in, found out about the nurse, and well, now I know why they left. I could have asked them, but they were just too nice to ever break my heart; they still are. This one time, I burnt the food, and they didn't say a word, just so my confidence wouldn't be affected. This, I guess, was a good way to raise someone, but, at the same time, I think positive criticism is needed. I mean, how will I know the food's bad if you choose not to say a word, right?

Anyway, back to what I was saying. Apparently, her denial of me was so bad that she refused to breastfeed me for a week. It took a lot of convincing from the doctors and the nurses. They practically had to remind her to be grateful since she wasn't able to conceive for the longest time; that she should consider this as her miracle baby. Eventually, they took me home, and then, four years later, they decided that dressing me up like a boy and calling me by a masculine name wasn't going to work, or that's what I assume happened. The nurse was nice enough to show me my old birth certificate which had the name 'Alexander.' That and the blue baby clothes in my old treasure box kind of helped me connect the dots. After all this, I didn't bother to find out who my parents were or why they hated me so much over something no one had control over. Instead, it just made me more ambitious. I wanted to succeed in life and move forward. I guess some of me still want them to regret giving up on me.

Sometimes, I regret finding out. Other times, I don't. It doesn't bother me much if they didn't want me. The simple fact was that they just didn't want me. It's as simple as that. I like to keep things simple and poetic. Simplicity leads to success, and poetry awakens the soul by giving life meaning. But that

doesn't mean I don't think a lot. On the contrary, I most certainly do. I go on tangents, I think too fast, and I don't like not knowing things.

My overthinking is bad to the point that I end up reading the last chapter of a book first so that I know the ending. Anything that happens in the middle won't be surprising because I already know how it's all meant to end. I'm not very specific about what I read or watch, but I am very particular about knowing what happens. I guess I do fear the unknown a lot. Which I do believe comes off as a surprise. I'm pretty shy, actually, and seem very unbothered. I don't speak as much as I think and enjoy staying in the background than in the spotlight. I'm exceptionally book smart, getting distinctions in my class since seventh grade. But on the other token, I'm not so street smart. If somebody were scamming me, I'm pretty sure it would take me a good fifteen minutes to figure it out. That doesn't mean I'd end up getting scammed, though, just that I would be slightly slower than others, and during that time span, I *might* get ripped off. All of this is unlikely, of course. I hope.

In this small town, I'm almost like a ghost. I blend in perfectly. I don't go out a lot; I prefer to stay in my room and prepare for the future. Even though I have never been to the city, my grandparents always say that my ambitions are higher than the buildings there. My Grandpa and grandma are the best miracles that have ever happened to me. They have always supported me and have never demotivated or questioned my dreams. Now that I think of it, maybe they are the reason I excelled and why I never gave up. They've done so much for me. They even saved up with me and helped me apply to nearby part-time jobs even though they never favored it. They wanted to always fund me, which was their way of expressing a language of love from their end. Of course, I understood, but I always insisted on working. We saved up together for my university, and through everything that we've faced, from the constant financial struggles to sharing meals out of love, the overly good traits I have are there because of their gentle upbringing,

Even though I've lived all my life here, I never really had the opportunity to connect with anyone from the village. The only 'friends' I had were the ones who wanted to copy my work. Other than that, no one. It wasn't because I was weird; I just never really spoke much. I have never interacted with the opposite gender, except once. That, too, in fifth grade.

His name was Thomas. He was in the same grade as me. He had brown hair, green eyes, light skin, and a stature that was much shorter than mine. We met

when he wrote me a note asking if I wanted to date him. Let's not forget, I was only eleven then, so I thought he meant to get married, and well, that freaked me out. It was just too much commitment; I barely knew what the sum of eight and eight was; I was hardly ready to have children! And so, I did the sanest thing any eleven-year-old would do; I cried and ran, which seemed harmless, but it caused a rumor to spread like wildfire. The students began to believe Thomas had cooties. You could say it was because of my reaction to the note. Again, I was only eleven. The damage caused by that rumor was so bad that the poor guy couldn't get a girlfriend until junior year. On the bright side, I'm happy to report that now they're getting married! So, in my defense, I, one way or another, helped him by not getting his heart broken until he met the one. All those girls would've hurt him, not because they were rude or the type to use people, but you just know when someone is right for you. And well, this woman was the one clearly.

You should see how they look at each other. It's as if one possesses the planets in their eyes, whereas the other knew about the secrets of the world's seven wonders. I do crave that, too, not with Thomas! Just with someone. That isn't my top priority, though. I wanted to get my degree first and then maybe settle with someone just like me, an understanding man who treats me equally and supports me just like my grandparents. My biological parents may not have raised me, but my grandparents left no room in my heart for a void to develop, which is why I won't ever go for a man who doesn't know how to treat me the way I deserve to be treated. I had my priorities set, and by now, you can tell how much, even now, I love my grandparents. Somehow, I keep mentioning them; they're just so prominent in my life. I want them to be there after I succeed. I want to give them the life they deserve.

And now, I am a step closer to getting there. I was always aware that my grades and outstanding reference letters would help me get into a good university, but I never thought I would get into the best university in Seattle; that too on a scholarship! I applied for criminal law, which is one of the hardest departments to get into, but I was certain to be a lawyer. They were always so fascinating, yet I would sometimes ponder over the drastic difference in my personality compared to the average, stereotypical lawyer. Or at least who I thought a lawyer was and how they acted. I've read some books, and well, let's just say I was on the other end of the spectrum. They were so outright blunt, confident, and organized.

I may be organized, but I was nowhere near confident and blunt; not even close. I liked my bubble way more than the thought of bursting someone

else's. And not to mention their consistent need to debate, the thought of conversing too much sounds draining but exciting at the same. I am well aware that I may have potential, but the thought makes me shake sometimes. Reading this may make you wonder, 'Why the hell is she choosing this as a career then?'

Well, just because I don't match the job description doesn't mean I don't want to do it. Besides, there's so much more to it than just personality. It requires a lot of brains too, and I know I have plenty. So, I'm pretty sure I can do it. And besides, being a lawyer isn't the only way I can use my criminal law degree. At the same time, I also believe the change shift from this small town to the city might just help me bloom. You never know what if I'm only an introvert here, but in college, I had the opportunity to explore myself. And who knows, I might just get out of my shell; I'm open to change.

The thought of the city has always excited me. I've dreamt of this moment for as long as I can remember. I was in eighth grade when I heard of Seattle university, but I never really told anyone but my grandma, who, of course, told my Grandpa. Both of them have saved up ever since, even though the possibility of it just being a phase was always an option.

"I believe you are meant for big things. Like the Sun, it may just be a star for other galaxies far away, but to us? Our plants might wither if they were gone for just a few days." My grandmother would say with a tone that dripped honey. Her eyes have always been soft towards me; today, they were proud, but the softness never left her.

Now that I think of it, my poetic urges might have been a product of her nurturing. She had always been the one to give an incident meaning, be it the happiest of events or the most tragic. Many would call it romanticizing but not me. Without her way of seeing the world, I think our hearts would be too heavy, and our lungs would've given up on us long ago. If this house stood on its foundation or I was able to actualize my dreams, it was because of her way of seeing the world. And, of course, my Grandpa's blind support and awkward dad jokes. And by now, I'm pretty sure it's more obvious how everything keeps coming back to them. And right now, this hug felt like the first goodbye hug out of the very few I have left.

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The days felt like a timelapse, and I began noticing things I had never done before. Both my grandparents seem so much older than I remember. Their

eyes are more tired than before, their hair whiter. I never really noticed Grandpa's lazy eye. I never knew he had one until now. His mustache was pure white, and his chin was covered with light hair. I never noticed that he hadn't shaved for a week. My grandma looked weaker than before, lighter too. Was she always so fragile? And her hair seemed thinner than before. How have I never noticed these things? A part of me didn't want to leave. The thought of leaving them all by themselves made me sick to my stomach. I wanted to take them with me, but I knew I couldn't. They loved this place; it was their home. It was mine too. And right now, I'd be lying if I said I wasn't aching right now. I was doing this for them and myself. I wanted all of us to experience the better side of life. I needed to do this for myself and them. They can't live here forever; they've never seen anything beyond it, and I aim to change that. The world doesn't just stop here. There's so much to experience and learn. There's so much to explore, so much to feel, see, taste, and hear. There's more to do than stay in this town and merely exist. I am pretty sure I don't need to explain any further. You probably get my point.

Packing was an ongoing process; the hugs grew tighter as New Year came closer. I was glad; at least we got to spend it together one more time before I left. To be fair, it felt as if I was going away forever, which wasn't true. Once I settled there and got a part-time job, I would be coming back every weekend, or that's what I hoped.

Anyway, I was going to Seattle University. I was excited, scared, happy, worried, and so much at once, but I knew that I wanted this with every atom in my body. I knew this was good for me; I just knew this chance would change my life. I don't know how to explain it; I just had this strong sense that was screaming at the top of its lungs. Something big was going to happen.

I don't know what it was, but I was looking forward to it, which was odd but not threatening. It felt as if something awaited me as if my name was written on it or something was written for me. Even though it wasn't a strong feeling, it wasn't easy to ignore. Yet, I couldn't put my finger on what it was. Well, whatever it was, it could wait. I still had a little more time here and wanted to cherish these moments and hold onto them a little longer. And well, I guess the best way to describe this is that it felt like I was seating myself and buckling my seatbelts, ready for this rollercoaster ride.

Chapter 2

Changing paths

Lia

1st January 2002, 1:30 am.

New Year's has never been eventful, from the age of four all the way to seventeen. It was always the three of us at the dinner table. The three of us would either play board games or cook together. Either way, the next step from that was to clean up and go to bed. This time, however, I was surprised with three cylindrical gift boxes placed on our dining table. Each had a personality of its own. There was a pink one, a gold one, and a black one. I was confused as to what might fit in a vertical box like that. Out of curiosity, my head tilted to the side as I analyzed these foreign yet neatly wrapped boxes from the kitchen door.

“You know those are for you, right?” Grandma said, without turning her back. She was washing the dishes.

“You didn’t have to,” I responded, my tone soft and low.

“We wanted to,” my Grandpa playfully shot back from the lounge.

Our home was small but cozy. Everything was close to another, and the shades and tints of brown were soothing. It felt like a cabin sometimes, which I didn’t mind. Many would think it’s suffocating, but the reality is that it was my safe space, and it was perfect for three people. Not too big, not too small, just small. The right amount of small.

“Well...” Grandma said out loud, snapping me out of my thoughts.

“Open them!” she finished, looking at me with her soft eyes.

She quickly wiped her hands on her apron and began pulling me out of the kitchen with her. She sat where she would usually sit. A groan came out from the lounge as my grandfather got up and made his way to us. He plopped down in his seat dramatically.

“I’m getting old,” he commented while stretching his arms out and resting them on the table.

Grandma rolled her eyes and slapped his arm, which he reacted to by pretend-dying with his tongue sticking out and eyes rolling to the back of his head. All of us laughed. After a few minutes of settling in and returning to our normal state, they both gestured at the presents.

“I am flattered,” I joked, raising my eyebrows in response to their humble gesture. I was going to miss them so much.

I reached out for the rosy pink present, not because I liked pink but because I knew it was from Grandma. It was also because I’d prefer to let her believe that all the pink items she had ever gotten me were the best presents ever. I never really liked pink, but she did. Everything, from her clothes to the tint of her tablecloth, earrings, and lipstick shades, they all screamed pink. She always associated it with elegance and said it had some sort of magic, which may not make sense to me, but if it makes sense to her. Honestly, I don’t mind it all.

The box opened vertically, and I peeked inside and smiled softly. Then, I looked back up at her and said, “A moon anklet, really!? You shouldn’t have!”

“Nonsense, it’s my love language,” she responded, scoffing.

I took out the anklet, admiring its silver beauty. I’ve always wanted a moon anklet. I just hoped it wasn’t expensive, but I can’t ask that. We had a no-price-tag-on-a-gift rule. Because of this, we couldn’t ask anyone how much the present cost or where they got it from. Grandpa said that was a page from the ‘gentlemen’s handbook.’

The anklet really was beautiful. I instantly tried it on, wrapping it around my thin ankle. I stuck my leg out, giving it a good shake as my grandma squealed lightly with joy.

“Okay, next!” Grandpa said out loud while he clasped his hands together.

“Okay! Okay...hmm, which one should I go for next?” I playfully said, trailing off as my fingers lingered over the remaining two boxes. I really couldn’t decide.

I knew the black one was from Grandpa. He always got his gifts wrapped in either royal blue or black. He always mentioned how these colors represented depth for him, expressing that there was more to a person. My Grandparents always had a tendency to give meaning to the littlest things, from the shape of a bow to the color of a vase. And honestly, I do too. I believe that there is no meaning; we provide the meaning. Life would be bland without the arbitrary pieces we fill it with. I get this perspective from them, and truly, to see beyond what the eye saw; was one of the greatest blessings in life.

I dragged the box across the table while I eyed my Grandpa with suspicion. He just looked away, pretending to be focus on something. I rolled my eyes playfully. He always had a thing for giving me the weirdest objects out there. Once, he got me a Vase with a hole in it. Apparently, that was him metaphorically telling me how I completed this family. Of course, I kept it. And I can’t deny his eye for turning meaningless objects so lightheartedly goofy and ironically meaningful at the same time.

“Should I shake it?” I asked with my right brow raised.

“Only if you want to break it,” he responded, mimicking my features.

“Touché,” I shot back with narrowed eyes which he did too.

I dramatically opened the box, not looking at the gift. Instead, I kept the intense stare-off going, which he broke off just to gesture toward the gift.

“You can’t tell if you don’t look,” he said with a shrug.

For a brief moment, I squinted at him until I looked down. An instant gasp escaped my lips, and my eyes widened at the sight of the gift. I could hear my grandfather chuckle, but I was just too consumed by the present to react. I couldn’t accept it, and I shouldn’t have had to; it was too expensive and looked fragile. I looked back up at him and shook my head as a light gesture to tell him that I just couldn’t, but he nodded to let me know I deserved it.

I felt tears begin to pool up in my eyes as I lifted the perfectly polished vintage watch. I squinted at it for a second, noting that something wasn’t right. I tried to click it and get it to start working. As soon I did, I heard my grandfather bursting with laughter.

“Vintage,” he said, still laughing hysterically.

I rolled my eyes and pouted; he got me once again.

“What does this mean?” I sarcastically asked, as I shook my head in disbelief. But I liked it. I liked the dynamic my grandfather and I had. It was so lively and meaningful.

“Since you insist…” he trailed off playfully, to which my grandma slapped his hand again with a chuckle.

“Time broke for me when you got that acceptance letter, it was the happiest I’ve ever seen you, and I wanted to stop us right there, in that hug. I wanted us to be infinite.” He paused and blinked off the tears as he looked away for a brief moment. “So that’s why the watch is broken. It stopped at the exact time that you got that acceptance letter. You didn’t notice it. But I was wearing it on my left arm…” he said, smiling at me.

Grandma reached out to hold his hand, and so did I.

“That’s a lot of love for a broken watch,” he joked with another brief chuckle.

My heart went soft at this. I felt an ache in my heart again. I was going to miss them. I really was.

“Thank you. And yes…you got me,” I finally responded in the softest voice. A light smile lit across my face as I wiped the tears that streamed down. I didn’t realize how all of us were in tears by now.

“And that,” Grandpa said, breaking the silence and straightening his back, “is my love language.”

“Oh! Stop it! This isn’t a competition,” Grandma shot back, nudging him.

“But if it were…I would’ve won,” he said, taunting her as he playfully bobbed side to side, egging her on.

“This is *my* moment,” I interjected, which made both of them pretend to look shocked.

“Well, not anymore,” Grandma responded, “it’s late, and you have your last day of work tomorrow. Look at the time.”

“I can’t.”

“She can’t,” my Grandfather and I simultaneously said as I held out the watch.

“You both know what I mean.”

“But I have one more present!”

“That, young lady, is actually for when you have a bad day…not for now, didn’t you read the note?” She teased, handing me a small note as she got up.

“What if the broken watch broke me…I should open it...” I whined, and my Grandpa patted me on the back as I got up.

They both kissed me on the head before going into their room. The truth was. I just wanted to spend more time with them. My flight was in a week, and I had already delayed it as much as I could, but I wanted more time. I wanted to witness their love language all over again before I left because I knew I wasn’t going to get any of this there; the dinner, the lighthearted jokes, the hugs. I couldn’t wait to go, but I also wanted to wait a little more. Call me selfish, if you may, but I wish I could have them and the opportunity to explore.

I went to my room, brushed my teeth, and changed into the pink pajamas that—you guessed it—grandma got me. I looked at the soft board. My to-do list was halfway complete, all I needed was a journal, and I had to pack a few of my books. I looked over at the huge shelf that took nearly one-fourth of my tiny room.

‘Might as well get that off my list too,’ I thought.

I wasn't tired. I wanted to take it all in. One last look at my board, I glanced at the plane ticket. My stomach turned with excitement. I ran my hands along the rectangular sheet, sighing with joy, back to the books before I seeped back into a daydream in the middle of the night.

Now the kinds of books I read were pretty confusing. I've read a lot of books, and I don't enjoy a specific genre, which explains the unrealistic number of books I own. I have more books than clothes, and that's a fact. The sad part was I could take all my clothes but not all my books. A real struggle if you asked me.

After almost an hour, I had a good game plan but a really messy room. Three all-time favorite books. Two books for the intellectually starving mind, one for comfort, and one book I hadn't read yet. Sounds easy, but, trust me, it wasn't. Another hour in, my room was practically unrecognizable, but I had my books sorted with clear reasons for why I wanted to take them with me. I also promised my other books that I'd take them with me next semester. Hopefully.

Anyway, my choices for my all-time favorites were; Gone Girl by Gillian Flynn, Shutter Island by Dennis Lehane, and The Woman in White by Wilkie Collins. I personally enjoy books that stimulate one's mind. I enjoy the thrill. Even though these books now exist in the form of films, I still prefer the books. One's imagination and perception can go wild when reading. I have always had a habit of reading the last page of a book before starting it. I can't help it. It's what makes me feel safe.

Moving on, the three informative books I picked were completely focused on criminology, as that is an interest I've always had. So, my top choices were Criminology: Theories, Patterns, Typologies (Tenth Edition) By Larry J. Siegel, and Crime & Criminology Sixth Edition by Rob White.

A book I've had for the longest time but never had the time to read, not even the last page, is Flowers by Daniel Keyes. I found the synopsis intriguing. It's been on my shelf for a year and a half now. Maybe it was time to finally pick it up.

Finally, my comfort book. I'm pretty sure after the books I've chosen earlier; you would be surprised. I am quite embarrassed though this book is my guilty pleasure. Regardless of all the books I've read, this has always been the one I go back to. The way it's written is just beautiful. The contemporary portrayal of love always gives me shivers. Yes, It's a romantic novel. I can't help it.

Just like all of you, I, too, crave the eternal kind of love where my lover and I's eyes linger and yearn for the other's graze. Call Me by Your Name by André Aciman. Cliché, I am aware. But I just cannot stop myself. It's not about the people; it's about how the writer expresses the love and attraction the two characters have for each other. The way they would try to catch the other's subtle gaze and the yearning for touch. It was so passionate yet so contemporary and soft at the same time. The ending of the book just hurt; it truly did. When a lover is unable to say what they wish to say, they sit in silence to take in the moment. I could keep going on about this.

By the looks of it, the sun was coming up, and I needed to sleep before I started work. I didn't mind sleeping in this mess; maybe I should have for once before this room lost its essence. In its place, maybe I will imbue that essence elsewhere. I just can't wait to leave a mark somewhere other than this small town. I can't wait to leave memory trails everywhere. Anywhere.

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Lia

7th January 2002.

After New Year's, all my grandparents and I talked about were old memories. We began reminiscing the times we never noticed our love for our small family, our bond, how we protected one another, the things we saw a glimpse of but never said out loud, the laughs, the cries, the goofy moments, and so much more. Some I didn't even remember. Some were just absurd, making the whole table laugh until we couldn't breathe or until Grandpa's eyes were pooled up. And some memories caused the room to grow silent as if we were taking it all in. It was as if we just wanted to bottle it all up and preserve it. And so, this was our way of doing it.

No one in town knew directly from us that I was leaving, but some came to visit and say their goodbyes; it was nice. They brought food and anything they could. The town's small, so I believe they got to know it from my workplace since I did have to resign. It was odd, nice, and uncomfortable all at once since I didn't know what to say or do. I liked being invisible, and this wasn't really how invisible people were treated. Yet it felt nice to know I'd be missed in some way.

So little time, so many things to let our heads wander over. Time had finally run out, the bookings were made, my bags were packed, and now we stood at

the terminal. We got a carrier to help us with my things because, trust me, it was a lot. I wore the watch and anklet I got, the golden box in my hand because I didn't know whether it was fragile or not, and for some reason, I didn't bother asking.

The departure terminal was empty, maybe because I chose my flight early morning. It was cheaper, and the airline was also reliable, according to the reviews. So, my fingers were crossed. It wasn't as hectic as I thought it would be, like in the books where they would forget things and rush here and there. Everything was pretty calm but emotional. It was in the air, the heartache and the longing. My grandmother was already crying, and, well, so was I. Grandpa was the only one trying to cheer us up with his usual lighthearted metaphors. I could see that he was holding himself back, though. He always wanted to be the strong one. His face was red, and his eyes pooled with tears; he just wasn't letting them flow.

"You remember what I told you, right?" he asked once again, for the hundredth time.

I nodded and gave both of them one last hug, and that's when the tears started flowing. We held each other tightly for a brief moment before I got my usual kiss on the head. It was time. I was nervous while making my way into the airport and to my respective aisle. I had never seen an airport from the inside before. I had only seen it in movies. Our local airport was smaller, though, or so I'm guessing, but it was still huge.

The white tiles were smooth, and it wasn't loud here even though there were people around. Finally, my ticket was cleared, and I was on my way. The tunnel-like path was a journey. I felt like a child on a field trip. This was really happening, and I was in complete awe of it.

The aircraft itself was a different kind of experience. I had read up about it, just in case, so I knew what was coming my way. On the outside, I might have looked like I knew what I was doing, but on the inside, I was a crippling excited child who was unprepared.

I had read up on turbulence and how bad it could get, but only time could tell. I didn't want anyone to know what I was mentally going through, so I kept to myself. I got the window seat, and luckily, no one sat beside me. The flight was empty, which was slightly worrying, but then again, I didn't expect a lot of people to come from my town specifically. Or that's what I'm assuming.

If it sounds like I'm going all over the place, it's because I was. My thoughts are clearly chaotic because of this excitement mixed with the fact that I already miss my grandparents. So many emotions at once, I suddenly feel like pacing. Yes, I may have forgotten to mention this, but I pace when I'm thinking too much. However, right now, all I could do was fasten my seatbelt since the sign had gone off. We were about to take off. Well, here it was; a new life, new beginning, and the magic of it all.

Chapter 3

Setting In

Lia

7th January, 2022.

It was a five-hour flight, and I didn't sleep the whole time. I was excited and scared. When the plane took off, my heart felt fluttery, and I thought I was having a heart attack. But, thank God, I had read up on how it feels to be on a flight, or else I would have actually thought it was a heart attack. This was a new feeling.

With all the excitement, I couldn't stop staring out the window. Everything was so tiny that it made me wonder how many people existed in the world. From a height like this, we were all ants. The thought made me feel many things, but mostly, it set my mind on the need to make life worth it. And this step; it was worth it.

The downside to flying for the first time was how the slightest turbulence would shake me back up whenever I tried to shut my eyes. I would genuinely panic in fear of the plane crashing. I did end up asking the air hostess if this was completely normal, to which she nodded. She was kind enough to get me a snack to keep me calm. I think she noticed how this was my first time on a plane. She kept making her rounds, always asking if I needed anything, which was very comforting.

Before landing, the flight attendant explained everything I needed to know. I already knew these things because of the plethora of tabs I had opened the night of this flight.

The landing wasn't as bad as I expected. The view was extraordinary as we approached the ground. I saw how the city went from looking like a tiny speck to its actual size through the window. I was completely mesmerized. My eyes were locked, and I had dissociated from my immediate surroundings. I didn't even notice how people started to get up from their seats and had already started to leave. I was just too caught up with looking at Seattle through the window. It just didn't feel real; It felt like a dream.

"Ma'am," I heard the kind air hostess behind me.

I instantly looked back, sheepishly smiling, as I realized everyone was already leaving.

The hostess helped me get my carry bag down from the bin above. I thanked her, shaking her hand excitedly. She seemed very confused by the gesture but smiled regardless. I was embarrassed. I won't lie, I thought that was something you did, but I

guess not. I finally got off the plane and rushed into the transport bus that would take me to the airport.

My grandfather had given me a tip to take the first bus and not wait. The smile on my face didn't fade, even for a second. I was processing everything I had seen so far. Everything seemed so surreal; the airport, the plane ride, the view from the plane, the departure—every single thing. It was taking me longer than usual to grasp everything I had seen with my own eyes. It felt like I was in a movie. At some point, I asked myself, 'Is this even happening?'

The bus finally stopped at a terminal entrance. Everyone got out, and I was practically pushed out. Not on purpose, mind you; it was more because of how many people got out at once. The terminal was cold, as if it was winter, and the shade of white was slightly different. The previous terminal was more abruptly white, whereas this one was a cooler tone of white with a hint of grey.

My eyes grew wider as I realized how big the airport was. I was on the escalator. As I looked around, it felt never-ending, but I had to follow the path I was directed toward, or I could get lost.

'If I'm too late, what if they send my baggage back?' I thought.

I didn't want to overthink it, but I couldn't help it simultaneously. I did want to explore the airport, but in the end, I chose not to. I didn't want to risk it. I took a glance at the board that guided travelers, checking which aisle I had to go for to get my luggage.

"17," I read. When I looked ahead of me, I realized I was at 15. "Okay, it isn't so far."

I got my luggage, which was quite easy since each bag had a pastel pink card attached to its front. Thank God I could convince everyone not to get me a set of pink luggage. I would have chosen to stay in Indiana just for that very reason. I may exaggerate a little, but I wouldn't say I like pink as much as people think I do. I found an empty trolley nearby to set my luggage in. Even though I was still tempted to look around, I chose not to once again.

This time, it was not of fear; it was more like I wanted to put a pin in it and discover it the next time I came back to travel. That would also give me enough time to understand the airport and what went where. I know, weird. But that's the only way I could know what already existed, explore it, and be fascinated by it. I have my ways, like everyone else. And I just like knowing; it feels safer. I'm not ready to be caught off guard at any point in life, which is hard, but I can *try* to have some form of control.

I finally made my way outside the airport. It was around noon, and the sun was at its peak. Winter was at the cusp of ending. Cold and gloomy days would soon morph into the heart of spring. It was beautiful. The roads were slightly glossy because of the

snow, the sidewalks were a combination of their original color mixed in with a little extra bit of white.

It snowed in Indiana as well, but this was different. It smelt different, like an industry or a new apartment. It was rather crisp and happening. People were all out and about, their murmurs causing a louder murmur in unison as they spoke to one other.

Behind me, a man was running, yelling for a cab. Clearly, he was in a rush. The woman beside me pulled out a cigarette, leaned against one of the nearest pillars, and took a long drag, her bold red lipstick smudging on its end.

The scene in front of me was apparent; a young girl was reuniting with their father. Their squeals and giggles brought life and amplified the collective sound of the chatter.

The man's wife gave him a quick, intimate kiss, and a soft smile spread across my lips. This, too, was beautiful. It created a longing in my heart that wasn't outright there but existed as a small whisper.

If I'm honest, I was mesmerized by the people. And the view in front of me. It was different than my town, louder and, rather, fuller. The buildings were dressed in a monotone color but varied in size. Some were tall, whereas some seemed like little block houses. They were all tightly packed together, which made me uneasy. The thought of being so close to such a narrow alley felt like there was no sense of privacy. Then again, curtains exist, and this was the city, after all. It was *full*.

My mind kept wandering; it couldn't just stick to one thing at a time. It kept jumping from place to place, scanning the smallest details. I had seen what Seattle looked like on the internet. But in person, I wasn't looking at art anymore; it felt as if I was looking at the inspiration behind it. With a loud exhale, I nodded in satisfaction and was now a part of this world.

I reached in for the printed paper neatly folded in the left pocket of my navy-blue coat. It had the address of where my hostel was located. I furrowed my brows as I read the sheet. A screenshot from Google Maps was printed on it to show me the distance. It was twenty-two minutes away from the airport but only ten minutes away from campus, which was a good thing.

Now all I needed was a cab. After pinning the location on my phone, I walked to the yellow and black taxi right in front of me. I told the cabbie the address.

"Do you have any bags?" he responded.

I nodded

A sigh escaped the old man's lips, followed by a polite smile.

“Let’s get them.”

The driver got out of the car and began to pick up my bags for me. I took a step forward to help, but he waved his hand at me as if to say, ‘I’ve got it.’ He dressed like he was in his late sixties, his shoes polished, but his facial features seemed tired. There were bags under his eyes, and his mustache had crumbs in them. He must’ve eaten in a hurry.

Most of my bags were in the trunk except for two that couldn’t fit, which the man was nice enough to set firmly in the front seat. I seated myself in the back with the location open on my phone and set it on my lap.

I gazed out the window, occasionally rechecking if we were taking the right route and making sure I wasn’t getting kidnapped or killed. My mind jumped to conclusions too soon, and all that reading had taken a slight toll on me. Through the windows, I could see that the city was full. There was traffic everywhere, and people filled the sidewalks. The city had it all; open-aired cafés, bars, and so much more. I couldn’t wait to stroll here and try out different kinds of food, and I also wondered if they had a library. The university certainly did, but it would’ve been great if there were public libraries nearby.

We finally came to a stop. I looked out of the window, eyes wide as I saw how beautiful it was. The color of the building was a much brighter shade of white in real life, and the windows were wide. From the outside, it looked very well-maintained and, well, huge.

“Twenty-one bucks,” I heard the cab driver say, shaking me out of my stance.

“Sorry,” I muttered as I handed him a twenty-dollar and a one-dollar bill.

The cab driver helped me with my luggage before he drove off. One of the caretakers soon greeted me, who instantly took my bags and asked me to follow them. I thanked them and made my way inside. My heart fluttered at the thought of what the place would’ve looked like from the inside. Even the doors smelled of fresh paint.

The big reveal made my jaw drop, but I had to recover quickly. The hallways were white with wooden flooring, and the furniture was minimalistic.

“Ah! You must be Lia. I hope this place wasn’t hard to find,” I heard an elderly woman say from the end of the hall.

She wore a black pencil skirt that went down to her knees with a white button-down. Her hair was almost the same shade as her top, and her eyes were the brightest shade of green. She was only a few inches taller than me because of her white heels. She seemed well-maintained and very classy.

“Hello, and no, not at all,” I replied with a polite smile.

She, ever so slightly, looked at me from head to toe as if scanning me. I felt awkward, but I didn’t know what to say in those few seconds, so I just stood there.

“Well!” she loudly clasped her hands together, making me jump. “Let’s get you to your room and give you a quick tour, I’m Ms. Annaliese Stuart, but you can call me Ms. Anne,” she added with a smile.

And with that, she started walking, or, more accurately, doing a fast-paced catwalk. I had to take quick steps to keep up with her.

“This is the common room, that is the kitchen, and this is the spare bathroom,” she said as we stepped foot into the living room.

The living room was also very minimalistic but stylish; a red rug with black sofas and an average-sized TV, and the kitchen with a grey countertop with white tiles. I really couldn’t believe this hostel was within my budget.

“Alright, moving forward!” she said aloud, again, causing me to jump.

“This is the floor with girls who share a room with another or three others. They have attached bathrooms.” She pointed at the floor with five doors and then made her way upwards.

She came to a stop on the second floor. There were five rooms. Two on the left and three on the right. Ms. Anne made her way to the end of the room, using her key to open the first door on the right.

“And this is your room,” she said with a smile at the doorway.

I made my way beside her, my eyes widening slightly in admiration. It was bigger in person than it was in the pictures.

“Okay,” she clasped her hands once again. She really had a habit of just derailing one’s train of thought.

“The bathrooms are the two rooms on the left. The rules are simple,” she stated as she turned to look at me. “If you make a mess, clean it. Break anything; you will have to pay for it. No pets, no parties, and buy your own groceries. Oh! And the payment is due every fifth of the month,” she said all at once as she looked back at me.

“There are other rules, but you’ll learn with time. You don’t seem like a troublemaker,” she added, eyeing me up and down.

Finally, she handed me the keys to the room and the keys to the front door.

“If you’re the last person in, be sure to lock it,” she said, patting my back. “I’ll let you freshen up.”

“Thank you, Ms. Anne,” I politely nodded as she walked off.

The caretaker kept my bags in my room and left. I made my way inside and shut the door behind me. The room had white walls, a single bed in the left corner, a wooden study table on the right with two shelves over and under the table, and a sliding wardrobe with a mirror opposite the bed. The window was on the right with white shutters.

It was cozy. I liked it. I sat on the bed and took it all in. This was really happening. I was happy. I opened the first suitcase. The first thing I wanted to do was stack my books and call my grandparents. I set the cylindrical gift I ever so conveniently carried the whole way here on the study stable. I tied my hair up in a bun and looked around before getting started.

‘Here's to new beginnings. And so much more.’